

Previous Year Questions

QUES

2 Mark Questions

Q1: What is meant by 'power sharing'? (2 Marks)

- Power sharing refers to the distribution of political power among different organs of government, different levels of government, social groups, and political parties or pressure groups.
- It is an intelligent way of accommodating diverse social groups and preventing conflicts, thereby ensuring the stability of a democratic political system.

Q2: Define 'Majoritarianism'. (2 Marks)

- Majoritarianism is a political belief that the majority community should be able to rule a country in whichever way it wants, by disregarding the wishes and needs of the minority.
- This belief often leads to the suppression of minority interests and can create a sense of alienation among them.

Q3: What is the ethnic composition of Belgium? (2 Marks)

- Belgium has a complex ethnic composition: 59
- In the capital city of Brussels, 80

Q4: What is the ethnic composition of Sri Lanka? (2 Marks)

- Sri Lanka has a diverse population. The major social groups are the Sinhala speakers (74
- Among the Tamils, there are Sri Lankan Tamils (13

Q5: Mention one prudential and one moral reason for power sharing. (2 Marks)

- A prudential reason for power sharing is that it helps to reduce the possibility of conflict between social groups.
- A moral reason is that power sharing is the very spirit of democracy, as a democratic rule involves sharing power with those who are affected by its exercise.

Q6: What does a 'system of checks and balances' mean? (2 Marks)

- This system, also known as horizontal power sharing, distributes power among different organs of government such as the legislature, executive, and judiciary.
- It ensures that no single organ can exercise unlimited power, as each organ checks the others.

Q7: How did the Sri Lankan government establish Sinhala supremacy? (2 Marks)

- In 1956, an Act was passed to recognize Sinhala as the only official language, thereby disregarding Tamil.
- The government also followed preferential policies that favoured Sinhala applicants for university positions and government jobs.

Q8: What is a 'Community Government' in Belgium? (2 Marks)

- A community government is a third kind of government in Belgium, elected by people belonging to one language community—Dutch, French and German—no matter where they live.
- This government has the power regarding cultural, educational and language-related issues.

Q9: What is the main difference between horizontal and vertical power sharing? (2 Marks)

- Horizontal power sharing distributes power among different organs of government at the same level, such as the legislature, executive, and judiciary.
- Vertical power sharing distributes power among different levels of government, such as the central, state, and local governments.

Q10: What were the main tensions between the Dutch-speaking and French-speaking communities in Belgium? (2 Marks)

- The Dutch-speaking majority was economically less prosperous and educated than the French-speaking minority.
- The French-speaking community was relatively rich and powerful, which was resented by the Dutch-speaking community. This created tensions between the two groups.

3 Mark Questions

Q11: Why is power sharing desirable? Give two reasons. (3 Marks)

- Power sharing is desirable for two main reasons: prudential and moral.
- Prudential reasons: It helps to reduce the possibility of conflict between social groups. Since social conflict often leads to violence and political instability, power sharing is a good way to ensure the stability of a political order. The example of Sri Lanka, where the refusal to share power led to a civil war, highlights the importance of this reason.
- Moral reasons: Power sharing is the very spirit of democracy. A democratic rule involves sharing power with those who are affected by its exercise, and who have to live with its effects. People have a right to be consulted on how they are to be governed. Power sharing gives legitimacy to a democratic government.

Q12: How did the Belgian leaders accommodate the diversity in their country? (3 Marks)

- Between 1970 and 1993, the Belgian leaders amended their constitution four times to work out an arrangement that would enable everyone to live together within the same country. This is known as the Belgian Model.
- The main features of this model include: a) the constitution prescribes that the number of Dutch and French-speaking ministers shall be equal in the central government; b) many powers of the central government have been given to state governments of the two regions; and c) Brussels has a separate government where both communities have equal representation.

Q13: Explain the consequences of majoritarian policies adopted by the Sri Lankan government. (3 Marks)

- The majoritarian measures adopted by the Sri Lankan government to establish Sinhala supremacy led to a feeling of alienation among the Sri Lankan Tamils.
- The Tamils felt that the constitution and government policies denied them equal political rights, discriminated against them in getting jobs and other opportunities, and ignored their interests.
- As a result, the distrust between the two communities turned into widespread conflict. It soon turned into a civil war, which caused a terrible setback to the social, cultural, and economic life of the country.

Q14: What is the difference between power sharing and power separation? (3 Marks)

- Power sharing is a broad concept of distributing power to prevent its concentration in one hand, which can be done through various forms, including separation.
- Power separation is a specific type of power sharing where power is divided among different organs of government (legislature, executive, judiciary) to ensure that each organ can check the other, thereby maintaining a balance of power.
- While all power separation is a form of power sharing, not all power sharing is power separation (e.g., power sharing among social groups or at different levels of government).

Q15: Explain the three main types of power sharing among different organs of the government in a democracy. (3 Marks)

- The three main organs are the Legislature, the Executive, and the Judiciary.
- Legislature: It is responsible for making laws for the country.
- Executive: It is responsible for implementing the laws made by the legislature and the decisions of the government.
- Judiciary: It is responsible for upholding the law, interpreting the constitution, and administering justice. This arrangement is a form of horizontal distribution of power.

Q16: What do you understand by 'vertical division of power'? Give an example from the Indian context. (3 Marks)

- Vertical division of power refers to the sharing of power among governments at different levels.
- For the entire country, there is a general government, and at the provincial or regional level, there are separate governments. This is also known as a federal form of government.
- In India, power is shared between the Union Government (at the national level), the State Governments (at the state level), and local self-governments like Panchayats and Municipalities.

Q17: How can power be shared among different social groups? Explain with an example. (3 Marks)

- Power can be shared among different social groups such as religious and linguistic groups. This is a crucial arrangement to give a fair share to minority communities.

- The 'Community Government' in Belgium is an excellent example of this. This government has the power to decide on cultural, educational, and language-related issues for a specific linguistic community, ensuring their interests are protected.
- In India, a similar concept is seen through reserved constituencies in the legislature, which ensure that people from socially weaker sections, like SCs and STs, get adequate representation in the government.

Q18: Explain the role of political parties, pressure groups, and movements in power sharing. (3 Marks)

- In a democracy, power is shared among different political parties that compete for power. This competition ensures that power does not remain in one hand for an indefinite period.
- When no single party gets a majority, different parties can form a coalition government, thus sharing power. This ensures that a broad range of views and interests are represented in governance.
- Pressure groups and movements also share power by influencing the government's decisions. They act as a check on the government and represent the interests of specific sections of society, such as workers, traders, industrialists, and farmers.

Q19: Compare the Belgian and Sri Lankan approaches to power sharing. (3 Marks)

- Belgium's leaders chose to accommodate social diversity by respecting the interests of different communities, leading to a successful power-sharing arrangement and political stability.
- Sri Lanka's leaders, on the other hand, adopted majoritarian policies that favoured the Sinhala majority, leading to the marginalization of the Tamil minority.
- This approach in Sri Lanka led to widespread conflict and a civil war, while the Belgian model successfully prevented civil strife and a possible division of the country on linguistic lines.

Q20: Why is it important to have a balance of power among government organs? (3 Marks)

- The system of checks and balances is a form of horizontal power sharing that ensures no single organ of the government can exercise unlimited power.
- Each organ, such as the judiciary, legislature, and executive, has the power to check the others.

- For example, judges are appointed by the executive, but they can check the functioning of the executive or laws made by the legislature. This arrangement prevents the concentration of power and safeguards the rights of citizens.

5 Mark Questions

Q21: How can power sharing arrangements be seen in India's political system? Explain the four forms of power sharing with examples from India. (5 Marks)

- In India's political system, power sharing is evident in various forms, making it a robust democracy.
- 1. Horizontal Power Sharing: Power is shared among the legislature (Parliament and state assemblies), the executive (the Union and state governments), and the judiciary (Supreme Court, High Courts, etc.). This 'system of checks and balances' ensures that no single organ exercises unlimited power. The judiciary can review laws passed by the legislature and actions of the executive.
- 2. Vertical Power Sharing: Power is shared among different levels of government. We have a Union Government for the entire country, State Governments for the different states, and local governments (Panchayati Raj and Municipalities). The Constitution clearly lays down the powers of each level.
- 3. Power Sharing among Social Groups: In India, reserved constituencies in legislatures and government jobs ensure that a fair share of power is given to socially weaker sections and minority communities. This is a form of power sharing to accommodate social diversity.
- 4. Power Sharing among Political Parties, Pressure Groups, and Movements: In India's multi-party system, power is shared among various political parties that compete for power. When two or more parties form an alliance to contest elections and form a coalition government, they share power. Pressure groups, such as trade unions and farmers' associations, also influence government decisions, thereby sharing power indirectly.

Q22: Describe the key features of the Belgian Model of power sharing that helped in solving ethnic conflicts. (5 Marks)

- The Belgian Model of power sharing, developed between 1970 and 1993, successfully resolved the ethnic tensions between the Dutch and French-speaking communities. Its

key features are:

- 1. Equal Representation in the Central Government: The Constitution mandates that the number of Dutch and French-speaking ministers in the central government must be equal. Special laws require the support of a majority of members from each linguistic group, preventing any single community from making unilateral decisions.
- 2. Decentralization of Power: Many powers of the central government were given to the state governments of the two regions (Flemish and Wallonia). These state governments were not subordinate to the central government.
- 3. Separate Government for Brussels: The capital city of Brussels, with its distinct ethnic composition (80
- 4. Community Government: A third type of government was created, known as the 'Community Government'. It is elected by people belonging to one language community—Dutch, French, and German—regardless of where they live. This government has powers related to cultural, educational, and language-related issues, ensuring the rights and interests of each linguistic group are protected.

Q23: What is majoritarianism? Explain the majoritarian measures adopted by Sri Lanka after its independence. (5 Marks)

- Majoritarianism is the belief that the majority community should be able to rule a country by disregarding the wishes and needs of the minority. This concept was applied in Sri Lanka after its independence in 1948.
- The democratically elected government of Sri Lanka adopted a series of majoritarian measures to establish Sinhala supremacy:
 - 1. Recognition of Sinhala as the Official Language: In 1956, an Act was passed to make Sinhala the only official language, thereby ignoring Tamil. This was a clear move to marginalize the Tamil-speaking population.
 - 2. Preferential Policies: The government followed policies that favored Sinhala applicants for university positions and government jobs. This created a sense of injustice among the Sri Lankan Tamils.
 - 3. State Protection of Buddhism: A new constitution stipulated that the state shall protect and foster Buddhism, the religion of the Sinhala community. This further alienated the Tamil-speaking population, many of whom were Hindus or Muslims.

- These measures gradually increased the feeling of alienation among the Sri Lankan Tamils and led to a civil war in the country.

Q24: Distinguish between the prudential and moral reasons for power sharing. Give an example for each. (5 Marks)

- Power sharing is desirable for both prudential and moral reasons, which are distinct yet interconnected.
- Prudential reasons are based on a careful calculation of gains and losses. They emphasize that power sharing will bring out better outcomes, such as social harmony and political stability. The primary goal is to minimize conflict and violence. For example, in Belgium, the leaders realized that a failure to share power would lead to a partition of the country, so they opted for a constitutional arrangement that accommodated both communities. This pragmatic approach ensured peace and unity.
- Moral reasons, on the other hand, emphasize the act of power sharing as a valuable and ethical principle. It is about the inherent rightness of a democratic process. A moral reason states that power sharing is the very spirit of democracy, as a legitimate government is one where citizens, through participation, acquire a stake in the system. For example, the Indian Constitution's provision for 'reserved constituencies' ensures that citizens from marginalized groups (SCs/STs) have a voice in the government, upholding the moral principle of inclusivity and equality, irrespective of whether it leads to immediate political stability.

Q25: Why is power sharing important for a democracy? Explain with a detailed answer. (5 Marks)

- Power sharing is considered the very spirit of democracy for several reasons:
- 1. Prevents Conflict: In societies with diverse social groups, power sharing is crucial for reducing the possibility of conflicts. By giving a voice to different groups, it prevents the tyranny of the majority and ensures a sense of belonging among all citizens. The story of Belgium and Sri Lanka perfectly illustrates this point.
- 2. Upholds Democratic Principles: In a democracy, all political power is derived from the people. Power sharing ensures that people are consulted on how they are to be governed and have a stake in the political system. This makes the government legitimate and accountable.

- 3. Checks and Balances: Power sharing among different organs of government (legislature, executive, and judiciary) creates a system of checks and balances. This prevents any one organ from becoming too powerful and ensures a balance of power, thereby protecting the rights and freedoms of the citizens.
- 4. Promotes Inclusivity: By sharing power with different social, religious, and linguistic groups, a democracy promotes inclusivity. Arrangements like community governments or reserved seats give a fair share of power to minority communities, preventing their marginalization and ensuring that their interests are not neglected.
- 5. Stability and Efficiency: Although it may seem to slow down decision-making, power sharing ultimately leads to a more stable political order in the long run. By accommodating diverse interests, it avoids the kind of political instability and violence that can arise from majoritarian rule, as seen in Sri Lanka.

Q26: What is meant by the 'horizontal distribution of power'? Explain with an example. (5 Marks)

- Horizontal distribution of power is a form of power sharing where power is distributed among different organs of the government, such as the legislature, executive, and judiciary. This is called horizontal because the organs are placed at the same level and exercise different powers.
- The key idea behind this arrangement is to ensure a 'system of checks and balances'. For example, in India, the Parliament (legislature) makes laws, the Union Government (executive) implements them, and the Supreme Court (judiciary) can check the constitutionality of the laws and the actions of the executive.
- This system ensures that no single organ can exercise unlimited power. The judiciary, for instance, can check the legislature's laws and the executive's actions to ensure they are within the constitutional framework. Similarly, the executive is responsible to the legislature. This horizontal division is crucial for preventing the concentration of power and maintaining the balance of power in a democracy.

Q27: Explain the concept of 'Federal Division of Power' and how it is implemented in India. (5 Marks)

- The federal division of power, also known as the vertical division of power, is a system where power is shared among governments at different levels. This includes a general

government for the entire country and governments at the provincial or regional level.

- In India, this system is implemented through three levels of government:
 1. Union Government: The central government that has authority over the entire country on subjects of national importance like defense, foreign affairs, and finance.
 2. State Governments: Governments for individual states that have powers over subjects of local or regional importance, such as police, agriculture, and health.
 3. Local Self-Governments: This includes Panchayats at the village level and Municipalities in urban areas. This is the lowest level of government that deals with local issues and ensures grassroots participation.
- The Indian Constitution clearly demarcates the powers of each level of government through various lists, such as the Union List, State List, and Concurrent List, ensuring a clear division of responsibilities and preventing conflicts over jurisdiction.

Q28: Trace the key decisions and actions that led to the civil war in Sri Lanka. (5 Marks)

- The civil war in Sri Lanka was a culmination of a series of majoritarian policies adopted by the Sinhala-dominated government after the country's independence in 1948. The key decisions and actions were:
 1. The Sinhala-dominated government used its majority to adopt a series of majoritarian measures, leading to a feeling of alienation among the Sri Lankan Tamils.
 2. The 1956 Act, which recognized Sinhala as the only official language, disregarding Tamil.
 3. The government followed preferential policies that favored Sinhala applicants for government jobs and university positions, discriminating against Tamils.
 4. The new constitution stipulated that the state shall protect and foster Buddhism, further marginalizing the Hindu and Muslim Tamils.
 5. These measures led to a rise in distrust and conflict between the two communities. Sri Lankan Tamils felt that the government and political parties were insensitive to their language and culture.
 6. Tamil political parties were formed, demanding the recognition of Tamil as an official language, regional autonomy, and equality of opportunity in education and jobs. These

demands were repeatedly denied.

- 7. The distrust turned into a widespread conflict, which escalated into a civil war, causing a terrible loss of life and a significant setback to the country's social and economic development.

Q29: What is the importance of power sharing in a democracy? Discuss with reference to the concepts of prudential and moral reasons. (5 Marks)

- Power sharing is crucial for the functioning of a democracy, and its importance can be understood through both prudential and moral reasoning.
- Prudential reasons focus on the practical benefits of power sharing. A key argument is that it helps to reduce the possibility of conflict between social groups. In a diverse society, the suppression of a minority group's interests by a majority can lead to political instability and violence. For example, the case of Sri Lanka shows how the refusal to share power with the Tamil minority led to a devastating civil war. Therefore, power sharing is a pragmatic way to ensure social harmony and the stability of a nation.
- Moral reasons, on the other hand, highlight the intrinsic value of power sharing. The moral argument is that power sharing is the very essence of democracy. It is a fundamental principle that people are the source of all political power, and a legitimate government is one where citizens have a say in how they are governed. By giving a voice to all citizens, including minorities, power sharing upholds the ideals of equality, justice, and liberty, which are the cornerstones of a democratic society. It ensures that the government is not just based on the rule of the majority, but is also inclusive and representative of the entire population.

Q30: Explain the concept of 'community government' in Belgium and its significance for a diverse society. (5 Marks)

- The 'community government' is a unique and innovative form of power sharing developed in Belgium. It is a third tier of government, distinct from the central and state governments.
- 1. Election Process: This government is elected by people belonging to one language community—Dutch, French, and German—no matter where they live. This means that members of a specific linguistic group can vote for representatives of their own community government, regardless of their geographical location.

- 2. Powers and Responsibilities: The community government has the power to make decisions regarding cultural, educational, and language-related issues. This gives each linguistic group autonomy over matters that are most important to their identity and heritage.
- 3. Significance for a Diverse Society: The community government is a powerful tool for accommodating social diversity and preventing conflicts. By giving each linguistic group a platform to manage its own cultural and educational affairs, it reduces the pressure on the central government and prevents potential conflicts that could arise from linguistic or cultural differences. It ensures that minority groups are not marginalized and that their distinct interests are protected, thereby fostering a sense of unity and mutual respect within the country. The success of this model has made it a symbol of successful power sharing in a multi-ethnic society.

